

# French, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they  
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at  
`code/learning/human-languages/french/lessons/`

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# Preface

This is the French volume of a wider project, and it is written for someone starting from zero, whose only shared language is English. French is taught one word at a time, and each word is taken apart — traced to its root (usually Latin), then forward to the English cousins you already own, so nothing is a fresh thing to memorize. *jour* ("day") arrives next to *journal* and *journey*; *salut* ("hi") turns out to wish you *health*, like *salute* and *salubrious*.

French has a close sibling in Spanish — both are worn-down Latin — so where a French word and its Spanish cousin descend from one Latin root, the book shows both and dwells on the *difference* between them (why the same *dies* became French *jour* but Spanish *día*; why French keeps *bonjour* singular where Spanish pluralizes *buenos días*). Every such comparison is supplied in full by the text — no prior Spanish is assumed; it is offered as enrichment, and a reader who happens to know Spanish simply nods along.

Three things shape every lesson: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of cousins; and the cultural or idiomatic reason a thing is said, not just the rule. Pronunciation is a short reference at the front, never a gate. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.



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# Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

Not to be read before starting. Each lesson names the sounds its word needs and points here for more. French spelling hides more sound than Spanish — silent letters, nasal vowels, liaison — so this page is worth dipping into, but it is never a wall to climb first.

## Three habits to unlearn

- **Silent final consonants.** Most are silent: *salut* = *sa-LU* (no *t*); *les* = *lay* (no *s*). Usually kept: final *c*, *r*, *f*, *l*.
- **Nasal vowels.** *on*, *an*, *in* send the vowel through the nose and silence the *n*: *bon* = *bõ*, *bien* = *byẽ*.
- **Liaison.** A silent final consonant can reconnect onto a following vowel (*vous avez* = *vou-zavez*). Later.

## Vowels

- **ou** = *oo* (*jour* = *zhoor*).
- **u** = a front-rounded *ee* with pursed lips (*salut*, *tu*) — no English equivalent, not *oo*.
- **oi** = *wa* (*soir* = *swahr*).
- **é** = crisp *ay*; **è/ê** = open *eh*.

## Nasal vowels

- **on/om** = nasal *õ* (*bon*, *bonjour*).
- **in/ain/ien** = nasal *ẽ* (*bien*, *bientôt*).
- **an/en** = nasal *ã* (*comment*, *enchanté*).
- A doubled *nn/mm* *cancels* the nasal: *bon* (*bõ*) vs. *bonne* (*bun*).

## Consonants that differ

- **j** (and soft **g**) = the *zh* of *measure* (*jour*).
- **r** = a soft guttural at the back of the throat — not the Spanish tap nor the English *r*.
- **h** = always silent. **ch** = English *sh* (*enchanté*). **gn** = *ny* (= Spanish *ñ*).

## Accents

French accents mark *vowel quality*, not stress (unlike Spanish): *é* (closed), *è/ê* (open), *ç* (soft *s*). French stresses the last syllable of a group, lightly and evenly.

## Chapter 1

# Greetings

The French greetings, built from their pieces — a word for “good,” words for “day,” “evening,” “night,” and the gender machine that decides their endings. French and Spanish are both daughters of Latin; where a French word and its Spanish cousin split from one Latin root, both appear here, because the *difference* between them is often the lesson — and the text supplies the Spanish word whether or not you have met it before. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C01-\*.md.*

### 1.1 *salut* — “hi,” a wish for your health

#### Sounds you’ll need

Final **t** is silent: *salut* = *sa-LU*. The **u** is the front-rounded French *u*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**salut** (informal “hi/bye”) ← Latin *salus, salutem* (“health, safety”). So *salut* literally wishes *health* — like old English “hail.” Cousins: **salute**, **salutation**, **salutary**, **salubrious**; and via *salvus* (“safe”), *save*, *salvation*.

#### Why it’s said this way

Strictly **informal**, and doubles as “bye.” For respect or a first meeting you reach for *bonjour* — just as Spanish, the other Latin daughter, reaches past its own casual *hola* for the fuller *buenos días*.

## 1.2 *bien* — “well”

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**bien** (“well”) ← Latin *bene* → **benefit**, **benevolent**, **benediction**. Spanish, from the same *bene*, kept the very same spelling, *bien* — the two Romance languages inherited the adverb almost unchanged.

A complete one-word answer: *Comment ça va?* → *Bien.*; intensified, *très bien*. The adverb (“well”); the *adjective* “good” is a different word, *bon*, next.

## 1.3 *bon* / *bonne* — “good”

### Sounds you’ll need

**bon** is nasal *bõ* (silent *n*); but **bonne** (feminine) is *bun* — the doubled *nn* cancels the nasal, so the two *sound* different despite looking alike.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**bon** / **bonne** ← Latin *bonus* / *bona* → **bonus**, **bonanza**, **bounty** (via *bonté*), *bonbon*. Spanish, from the same *bonus* / *bona*, made *bueno* / *buena* — where French kept the *o* short, Spanish broke it into a diphthong (*o* → *ue*).

### Grammar Lens

*bon* **agrees** with its noun in gender and number — *bon* (m.), *bonne* (f.), *bons* (m.pl.), *bonnes* (f.pl.). This gender-agreement of adjectives is Latin’s legacy across the Romance languages (Spanish runs the same machine on *bueno* / *buena*). You’ll watch it: *bon jour* (m.) but *bonne nuit* (f.).

1.4 *le / la / les* — “the,” and the gender it carries

## The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**le** ← *ille*, **la** ← *illa*, **les** ← *illos* — Latin demonstratives (“that one/those”) worn down into “the.” Spanish, from the very same *ille* / *illa* / *illos*, has *el* / *la* / *los*; and those same Latin demonstratives also gave French **il** / **elle** (“he/she”). (English “the” is Germanic — unrelated.)

## Grammar Lens

Every French noun is masculine or feminine — Latin’s three genders (masculine, feminine, neuter) collapsed to two, the neuter folding mostly into the masculine. Learn each noun *with* its article. French has one convenience: in the plural, both genders share a single article, *les*.

1.5 *jour* — “day,” and the road to English *journey*

## Sounds you’ll need

**j** = *zh* (as in *measure*); **ou** = *oo*. So *jour* = *zhoor*.

## The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**le jour** (masc.) ← Latin *diurnum* (“daytime”), from *dies* (“day”). That detour through *diurnum* is why *jour* looks nothing like Spanish *día* (which took *dies* directly). Cousins, mostly via French: **journal**, **journey** (a *day’s* travel — *journée*), **sojourn**, **adjourn** (*à jour*); and via *dies*: **diurnal**, **diary**.

*So English journey and Spanish día are cousins, meeting at Latin dies — one through French, one direct.*

## Grammar Lens

*jour* is **masculine** (*le jour*). Plural adds a silent *-s* (*les jours*) — heard only in *les*.

## 1.6 *bonjour* — assembled, and *not* plural

*bon* (“good”) + *jour* (“day”) = “good day,” one word, *bõ-zhoor*; *bon* is masculine because *jour* is.

### Why it’s said this way

The contrast to bank: Spanish says *buenos días* — **plural**, the fossil of a blessing. French says *bonjour* — **singular**, just “good day.” Same two blocks, same roots; Spanish pluralized the blessing, French didn’t. And culturally *bonjour* is near-obligatory — opening a shop or a conversation *without* one reads as rude.

## 1.7 *soir* — “evening,” the same “late” Spanish used

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**le soir** (masc., *swahr*) ← Latin *sērum* (“the **late** hour”), from *sērus* (“late”). Cousin: *soirée*. Spanish, from the same instinct, named its “afternoon” *tarde* ← *tardus*, “**late**” — two languages, two “late” words, the same idea of naming the later day after its lateness.

### Grammar Lens

*le soir* is **masculine**; plural *les soirs* (the *-s* silent, heard only in *les*).

## 1.8 *bonsoir* — good evening

*bon* + *soir* (masc.) = “good evening,” *bõ-swahr*; *bon* stays masculine. The evening swap for *bonjour*, and — like Spanish *buenas noches* — usable both arriving and leaving.

## 1.9 *nuit* — “night,” and a sound-change mirroring Spanish

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**la nuit** (fem., *nwee*) ← Latin *noctem* (*noct-*) → **nocturnal**, **equinox**.  
The change is a *rule*, side by side with Spanish: Latin *-ct-* → Spanish *-ch-*, French *-it-*.

| Latin         | Spanish | French | English |
|---------------|---------|--------|---------|
| <i>noctem</i> | noche   | nuit   | night   |
| <i>lactem</i> | leche   | lait   | (lact-) |
| <i>factum</i> | hecho   | fait   | fact    |

### Grammar Lens

*nuit* is **feminine** (*la nuit*, from feminine Latin *nox*) — which is why “good night” is *bonne nuit*. Plural *les nuits*.

## 1.10 *bonne nuit* — good night, and the feminine *bon*

*bonne* (fem.) + *nuit* (fem.) = “good night” (*bun nwee*). At last *bon* in its feminine coat — and the whole agreement rule in one view:

*bonjour* (*jour* m. → *bon*)    *bonsoir* (*soir* m. → *bon*)    *bonne nuit* (*nuit* f. → *bonne*)

### Why it’s said this way

Unlike *bonsoir* (an evening greeting), *bonne nuit* is a **farewell for bed**. French keeps them separate where Spanish overloads *buenas noches* for both. Next chapter: introducing yourself, and French’s own *tu* vs. *vous*.





## Chapter 2

# Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

— *Je m’appelle Mira.*  
— *Comment vous appelez-vous?*  
— *Je m’appelle Arun.*  
— *Enchanté.*

We build it the same way as the greetings: each piece taken apart first, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C02-\*.md.*

### 2.1 *je* — “I,” the smallest word you own

#### Sounds you’ll need

*zhuh* — soft *j* (as in *measure*), a light *uh*. Before a vowel it elides to *j’*:  
*je ai* → *j’ai*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**je** (“I”) ← Latin *ego*. The Latin form survives raw in English **ego**, **egoist**, **egotism** — so the word for “I” and the psychologist’s “ego” are the *same* ancient word, one worn down to a whisper (*je*), one kept whole. (Spanish took *ego* to *yo*; French wore it further, to *je*.)

## 2.2 *me* — “myself,” the same word as English *me*

### Sounds you’ll need

*muh* — a light *uh*, like *je*. Before a vowel it elides to *m’*: *me appelle* → *m’appelle*.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**me** (“me, myself”) ← Latin *mē* (the accusative “me”) — literally the *same* word as English **me**. The whole family grows from one Proto-Indo-European root *\*me-*: English **me**, **my**, **mine**; Latin *mē* and *meus* (“my,” which became French *mon* / *ma* / *mes*). So the little *m’* in *je m’appelle* is a first-person marker you have owned in English all your life.

### Grammar Lens

**The reflexive set.** *me* is one of three pronouns that bounce a verb back on its doer: *me* (myself), *te* (yourself), *se* (himself/herself). Their roots run in parallel: *te* ← Latin *tē* (cousin of archaic English **thee**), *se* ← Latin *sē* (the “self” root behind **separate** and, distantly, **suicide**, *suī* “of oneself”). You’ll use *me* to say your name and *te* in the informal “what’s your name?”

## 2.3 *(s’)appeler* — “to call,” and “to call *oneself*”

### Sounds you’ll need

*a-play*; the *-er* ending of the infinitive is a plain “ay.” In *m’appelle* the doubled *ll* keeps a crisp “l.”

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**appeler** (“to call”) ← Latin *appellāre* (“to address, call by name”). A rich English family: **appeal** (call to a higher authority), **appellation** (a name), **appellate** (a court that hears appeals), **appellant**. To name someone is, at root, to *call* them.

## 2.4. JE M'APPELLE... — “MY NAME IS...,” LITERALLY “I CALL MYSELF”<sup>11</sup>

### Grammar Lens

**Reflexive verbs — doing something to yourself.** Pair this verb with the *me* you just met (§2.2) and you get *s'appeler*, “to call *oneself*”: *je me appelle*, “I call myself.” That is how French says a name — not “my name is” but “I call myself.” (English has the same move, hidden in “I call *myself*.”)

## 2.4 *je m'appelle...* — “my name is...,” literally “I call myself”

*je* (I, §2.1) + *me* (myself, §2.2, elided to *m'* before the vowel) + *appelle* (call, §2.3) = **je m'appelle...** — word for word “I call myself...,” and the everyday way to say “**my name is...**” *Je m'appelle Arun.* = “My name is Arun.” Three atoms, each traced; now they click together.

### Why it's said this way

French *prefers* this verb-based “I call myself” to a literal “my name is.” The literal version, *mon nom est...* (“my name is...,” with *nom* ← Latin *nōmen* → English **noun**, **nominate**, **nominal**), exists and is understood, but it sounds stiff or officious — a form for a passport desk, not a introduction. Reach for *je m'appelle*.

## 2.5 *tu / vous* — “you,” familiar and formal

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**tu** (familiar “you”) ← Latin *tū*; **vous** (formal/plural “you”) ← Latin *vōs* (“you all”). English lost the distinction — old *thou* was the *tu*, now vanished, leaving one flat *you* for everyone.

### Grammar Lens

**Two “you”s, chosen by register.** *tu* is for friends, family, children, peers; *vous* is for strangers, elders, anyone you’d show respect — and it doubles as the plural “you all.” French makes politeness by using the *plural* on one person (the verb has its own name for this: *vouvoyer*). This is the same politeness Spanish builds with *usted*, but by a differ-

ent mechanism: Spanish invented a new pronoun (from “your grace”); French just uses “you all” for one respected person. Using *tu* too soon can read as over-familiar — when unsure, *vous*.

## 2.6 *comment* — “how,” the same *quomodo* behind Spanish *cómo*

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**comment** (“how”) ← Latin *quo modo* (“in what manner”), the two words fused and worn down. That exact phrase *quomodo* also became Spanish *cómo* — two Romance languages, one Latin “in-what-way,” reshaped differently. The piece *modo* (“manner, measure”) is itself alive in English **mode**, **model**, **moderate**.

### Grammar Lens

French uses *comment* (“how”) where English uses “what” for names — literally “*how* are you called?”, not “*what* is your name?”. The question is about the *manner* of your calling. Keep the French logic: *comment* = “how,” and the name-question is built on it.

## 2.7 *comment vous appelez-vous?* — “what’s your name?”

*comment* (how) + *vous appelez-vous* (“do you call yourself,” with the verb and *vous* swapped for a question) = literally “**how do you call yourself?**” — the polite “what’s your name?”

### Grammar Lens

**Asking by inversion.** A statement, *vous vous appelez* (“you call yourself”), becomes a question by flipping verb and pronoun: *vous appelez-vous?* (with a hyphen). The informal version simply swaps in *tu*: *comment tu t’appelles?* — note *te* elides to *t’*, exactly as *me* became *m’*.

## 2.8 *enchanté* — “delighted,” i.e. “pleased to meet you”

### Sounds you’ll need

*ahn-shahn-TAY*: two nasal vowels (*en*, *an*), then a clean “tay.” *ch* = English *sh*.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**enchanté** (“delighted”) ← Latin *in-* (“upon”) + *cantāre* (“to sing, chant”): to *enchant* was literally to *sing a spell upon* someone. English kept the magic in **enchant**, **incantation**, and the plain **chant**. To say *enchanté* on meeting someone is to say, gallantly, “I’m *enchanted*.”

### Grammar Lens

**It agrees with *you*.** *enchanté* follows the gender rule from §1.4: a man says *enchanté*, a woman *enchantee* (an extra *-e*, same sound). The adjective reports the speaker’s own gender.

## 2.9 The whole exchange

| French                            | English              |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------|
| <i>Je m’appelle Mira.</i>         | My name is Mira.     |
| <i>Comment vous appelez-vous?</i> | What’s your name?    |
| <i>Je m’appelle Arun.</i>         | My name is Arun.     |
| <i>Enchanté.</i>                  | Pleased to meet you. |

Every piece was built from a root: *je* from *ego*, *appeler* from *appellāre* (appeal/appellation), *comment* from *quo modo*, *enchanté* from *in-cantāre*. Next chapter: *Comment ça va?* (“how’s it going?”) and answering with *bien* again — the recursive responding cycle.



## Chapter 3

# How Are You?

Now the small talk that follows a name — thanking, answering a thank-you, and asking how someone is doing. French asks that last question with a verb of *motion*: not “how are you?” but “how does it *go*?”

- *Comment allez-vous?*
- *Très bien, merci. Et vous?*
- *Comme ci, comme ça.*

Each piece is taken apart first, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C03-\*.md.*

### 3.1 *merci* — “thank you,” and it means *mercy*

#### Sounds you’ll need

*mehr-SEE*, with the soft guttural French *r* made at the back of the throat (never a tapped or rolled *r*). The stress falls at the end: *mehr-SEE*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**merci** (“thank you”) ← Latin *mercēs* (“wages, reward, price, that which is earned”). Saying *merci* originally invoked a **reward** owed for a kindness — and, in old religious use, a plea for divine **mercy**, a reward you have not earned.

That one root *merc-* (“pay, trade, reward”) pays out a large English family: **mercy**, **merciful** (the reward/pity sense); **mercenary** (a soldier who fights for *wages*); and, through Latin *mercārī* (“to trade”), **merchant**, **commerce**, **market**, **mercantile**. Even **Mercury**, the Roman god of merchants, is family.

### Why it's said this way

**Three sisters, three pictures of gratitude.** The Romance languages each chose a different metaphor for “thank you.” French *merci* comes from *mercēs*, a **reward** (and so, mercy). Spanish *gracias* comes from Latin *grātia*, **grace** or favour. Portuguese *obrigado* comes from Latin *obligātus*, “I am **obliged**.” Same feeling, three quite different pictures — French hands you a reward, Spanish hands you grace, Portuguese declares itself in your debt.

## 3.2 *de rien* — “you’re welcome,” literally “of nothing”

### Sounds you’ll need

*duh ryan*, where that final syllable is **nasal**: the air goes out through the nose and there is no hard *n* at the end. Two things to keep: the nasal ending of *rien*, and the guttural French *r* at the back of the throat.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**de** (“of, from”) ← Latin *dē*. **rien** (“nothing”) ← Latin *rem*, the accusative of *rēs*, “a thing.”

In Latin *rem* meant a **thing**, something real. French kept using it inside negations — *ne ...rien*, “not ...a thing” — until the word for *thing* absorbed the negation around it and **rien came to mean “nothing” all by itself**. Latin *rēs* also gives English **real**, **republic** (*rēs pūblica*, “the public thing”), and **rebus**. So *rien* is, at the root, a *real thing* that learned to mean nothing at all.

### Why it's said this way

**The same move, twice.** Spanish did the identical thing with *nada*, which comes from Latin *nāta*, “a born thing” — again a *thing* word that collapsed into a *nothing* word. The two replies sit side by side:

| Language | “You’re welcome” | The “nothing” word                         |
|----------|------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| French   | <i>de rien</i>   | <i>rien</i> ← <i>rem</i> , “a thing”       |
| Spanish  | <i>de nada</i>   | <i>nada</i> ← <i>nāta</i> , “a born thing” |



### 3.3. ALLER — “TO GO,” THE VERB BEHIND “HOW ARE YOU?”<sup>17</sup>

Two sister languages, one instinct: wave the favour off as no *thing* at all.

### 3.3 *aller* — “to go,” the verb behind “how are you?”

#### Sounds you’ll need

The infinitive ending *-er* is a clean “ay”: *aller* = *ah-LAY*. The doubled *ll* is just one *l* sound, and the *r* of the ending is silent.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**aller** (“to go”) is one of the great messes of French: it is **suppletive**, meaning it was stitched together out of **three** different Latin verbs, and the seams still show in its everyday forms.

*je vais* (“I go”) ← Latin *vādere*, “to go, to rush” → English **invade**, **evade**, **wade** — all going-words.

*nous allons* (“we go”), and the infinitive *aller* itself, ← Latin *ambulāre*, “to walk” → English **amble**, **ambulance** (a walking hospital), **preamble**, **perambulate**.

*j’irai* (“I will go”) ← Latin *īre*, “to go” → English **exit** (*ex-it*, “he goes out”), **transit**, **initial**.

So one French verb carries three separate Latin roots for motion.

#### Grammar Lens

“**Going**” used for “**being**.” You do not need to conjugate *aller* yet — only to recognize one form: *ça va*, “it goes” (the *va* is the *vādere* piece). Many languages borrow a verb of motion to talk about a *state*: English asks “how are you getting on?” or “how’s it going?” French made exactly that the standard question. Spanish instead asks with *estar*, “to stand” (*¿cómo estás?*). One language stands, the other walks — two different pictures of a life.

### 3.4 *comment ça va?* — “how are you?”

*comment* (how, §2.6) + *ça* (it, this) + *va* (goes, from *aller*, §3.3) = **Comment ça va?** — word for word, “How does *it* go?” and the single most

useful question in spoken French.

*ça* means “it, this,” worn down from Latin *ecce hoc*, “behold this.” The two-word version, *Ça va?* (“It goes?”), is what people actually say — and you can answer it with the very same two words: *Ça va*. (“It goes” = “I’m fine.”)

#### Grammar Lens

**A ladder of three registers.** French offers a neat climb from casual to formal. *tu* is the familiar “you” (a friend, a peer); *vous* is the formal or plural “you” (a stranger, an elder, a group).

| Register             | Question                                  | Literally                            |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Casual, universal    | <i>Comment ça va?</i> (or <i>Ça va?</i> ) | “How does <i>it</i> go?”             |
| Informal, one friend | <i>Comment vas-tu?</i>                    | “How go <i>you</i> ?”                |
| Formal or plural     | <i>Comment allez-vous?</i>                | “How go <i>you</i> ( <i>vous</i> )?” |

*vas* and *allez* are simply the *tu* and *vous* forms of *aller*. For a stranger or a boss, reach for *Comment allez-vous?*

#### Sounds you’ll need

*comment* ends in a nasal vowel and a silent *t*: *ko-mahn*. But in *Comment allez-vous* that silent *t* wakes up and glues onto the following vowel — this is called **liaison** — *ko-mahn-ta-lay-VOO*.

### 3.5 *comme ci, comme ça* — the classic French shrug

Someone asks *Ça va?* and you are neither great nor bad. The perfect answer — a phrase English borrowed whole — is **comme ci, comme ça**, literally “like this, like that.” A verbal shrug of the shoulders.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**comme** (“like, as”) ← Latin *quōmodo*, “in what manner” — the *same* root as *comment* (“how”, §2.6). One Latin word, two French children: *comment* is “in what manner?” asked as a question, *comme* is “in the manner of, like.”

**ci** (“here, this”) ← Latin *ecce hic*, “behold here.” **ça** (“there, that”) ← Latin *ecce hoc*, “behold this” — the very same *ça* as in *Ça va?*

So you are literally waving a hand: *a bit like this way, a bit like that way* — neither up nor down.

### Grammar Lens

**Your answer set for *Ça va?*** Recall *bien*, “well” (§1.2, from Latin *bene*); *Ça va bien* is “it’s going well.”

| Answer                    | Sense                  |
|---------------------------|------------------------|
| <i>(Très) bien, merci</i> | (Very) well, thank you |
| <i>Ça va</i>              | Fine, okay (“it goes”) |
| <i>Comme ci, comme ça</i> | So-so                  |
| <i>Pas mal</i>            | Not bad                |

### Why it’s said this way

Every language has its shrug, and each paints it differently: Spanish says *más o menos* (“more or less”) or *regular*; Italian says *così così* (“so so”); French says *comme ci, comme ça* (“like this, like that”). Same gesture, three pictures.

## 3.6 The whole exchange

No new words — this chapter’s atoms assemble into a real exchange, run once formally and once informally. The glue is *et vous?* / *et toi?*, “and you?” (*et* = “and,” from Latin *et*; *toi* is the stressed form of *tu*). It bounces the question straight back, exactly as Spanish does with *¿y usted?* / *¿y tú?*

**Formal** — a stranger, an elder:

— *Bonjour. Comment allez-vous?*  
 — *Très bien, merci. Et vous?*  
 — *Comme ci, comme ça.*  
 — [after a small favour] *Merci!* — *De rien.*

**Informal** — a friend:

— *Salut! Ça va?*  
 — *Ça va, et toi?*  
 — *Comme ci, comme ça.*

| French                     | English                 |
|----------------------------|-------------------------|
| <i>Merci.</i>              | Thank you.              |
| <i>De rien.</i>            | You're welcome.         |
| <i>Comment allez-vous?</i> | How are you? (formal)   |
| <i>Comment vas-tu?</i>     | How are you? (informal) |
| <i>Ça va?</i>              | How's it going?         |
| <i>Ça va bien.</i>         | It's going well.        |
| <i>Comme ci, comme ça.</i> | So-so.                  |
| <i>Pas mal.</i>            | Not bad.                |

Every piece came from a root: *merci* from *mercēs* (“reward, mercy”), *rien* from *rem* (“a thing”), *aller* from *ambulāre*, *vādere* and *īre*, *comme* from *quōmodo*. Next chapter: the farewells — *au revoir*, *à bientôt*, *à demain*.

## Chapter 4

# Farewells

You can open a French conversation; now close it. French has one plain goodbye and a small family of soft ones, all built the same way — the preposition *à* (“to”) followed by a time word:

— *Bon...à demain, Marc.*  
— *À demain, Chloé. Au revoir!*

Practice lessons: *lessons/FR-CO4-\*.md*.

### 4.1 *au revoir* — “goodbye,” i.e. “until we see each other again”

#### Sounds you’ll need

*oh ruh-VWAHR*, with two guttural French *r*’s made at the back of the throat. The letter pair *oi* is pronounced *wa*, so *-voir* = *vwahr* (the same *oi* as in *soir*, §1.7).

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**au revoir** is *au* + *revoir*, “at the re-seeing.” *au* is a fusion of *à* (“to, at”) + *le* (“the”). *revoir* is **re-** (“again”) + **voir** (“to see”), so the whole phrase literally means “**until the seeing-again**” — a small promise that this is not the end.

*voir* comes from Latin *vidēre*, “to see,” one of the richest roots English owns: **vision**, **visible**, **visit**, **visa**, **view**, **video** (“I see”); and with prefixes, **revise** (“look again”), **evident** (“seen out”), **provide**, **supervise**, **survey**.

**Why it's said this way**

**A goodbye that sees.** German builds its farewell out of exactly the same idea: *Auf Wiedersehen* is *auf* (“on”) + *wieder* (“again”) + *sehen* (“to see”) — “on the seeing-again.” French and German, side by side, both promise a re-seeing. Spanish *adiós* takes a different road entirely: it commends you *to God* (*a Dios*). Same moment of parting, two quite different pictures.

**4.2 à plus tard — the casual “see you later”****Sounds you'll need**

In the full phrase, *plus* is *ploo* with a silent *s*, and *tard* is *tar* with a silent *d*: *ah ploo TAR*. But in the clipped form *à plus*, the *s* is sounded: *ah PLUSS*.

**The word, taken apart — and its English cousins**

**à** (“to, at”) ← Latin *ad* — French’s all-purpose farewell preposition.  
**plus** (“more”) ← Latin *plūs*, the very **plus** you already write in English, and the *plu-* of **plural** and **surplus**. **tard** (“late”) ← Latin *tarde*, “slowly, late” → English **tardy** and **retard** (“to hold back, make late”).

So *à plus tard* is literally “to more late” — see you at some later point. Among friends it shrinks to just *à plus*.

**Why it's said this way**

Spanish inherited that identical Latin *tarde* — but the two languages grew it in different directions. French kept it meaning **late** (*tard*); Spanish grew it into **afternoon** (*tarde*). One Latin word, two everyday meanings. And where French leans on *à* for its soft goodbyes, Spanish leans on *hasta* (“until”): *hasta luego* is the twin of *à plus tard*.

### 4.3 à *bientôt* — “see you soon”

#### Sounds you’ll need

*bien* is nasal — *byan*, air through the nose, no hard *n*. *bientôt* = *byan-TOH*; the circumflex on *ô* simply marks a long *o*, and the final *t* is silent. The whole phrase: *ah byan-TOH*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

à **bientôt** = “to soon” → “see you soon.” The second word is a compound you can pull apart: **bien** (“well,” §1.2, from Latin *bene* — the *bene* of **benefit**) + **tôt** (“early, soon”) = “well-soon,” that is, *quite soon*. The circumflex on *ô* is itself a history lesson: in French a circumflex usually marks an **s that dropped out**. *hôtel* was once *hostel*; *forêt* was once *forest*; and *tôt* came from an older *tost*. The little hat is the ghost of a lost *s*.

#### Grammar Lens

**bien, the intensifier.** You met *bien* as “well,” an answer to *Ça va?* Here it does a second job: it glues onto another word to strengthen it. *bien* + *tôt* = *bientôt*, “soon indeed.” French loves this move — *bienvenue* (“welcome”) is literally *bien* + *venue*, “well-come.” Same word, new trick.

### 4.4 à *demain* — “see you tomorrow”

#### Sounds you’ll need

*demain* = *duh-MAN*, where the ending *-ain* is a nasal vowel (the same nasal as in *pain*, *main*) and the final consonant is silent. The whole phrase: *ah duh-MAN*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

à **demain** = “to tomorrow” → “see you tomorrow.” **demain** (“tomorrow”) ← Latin *dē māne*, “from the morning”: *dē* = “from,” *māne* = “in the morning.” The next morning is *tomorrow*, and the two words fused into *demain*.

English keeps that *māne* too, in the poetic **matins** (morning prayers) and in **matinée**, a daytime show.

### Why it's said this way

**The hidden twin.** Spanish *mañana* (“tomorrow, morning”) comes from Latin (*hōra*) *maneana*, built on the *same māne* (“morning”). So French *demain* and Spanish *mañana* are cousins through one Latin word — both turning “morning” into “tomorrow,” just assembled differently: French says *from-morning*, Spanish says *morning-ish hour*.

### Grammar Lens

**The à ... farewells, complete.** All of French’s soft goodbyes are *à* + a time word, where Spanish uses *hasta* (“until”) + a time word:

| French                                 | Spanish             | When                |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| <i>à plus tard</i> (or <i>à plus</i> ) | <i>hasta luego</i>  | Later — the default |
| <i>à bientôt</i>                       | <i>hasta pronto</i> | Soon                |
| <i>à demain</i>                        | <i>hasta mañana</i> | Tomorrow            |

And *au revoir* for the plain goodbye.

## 4.5 Saying goodbye, start to finish

No new words. The farewells now close a real conversation and fold back into everything since *salut*.

| You are...                      | Say                   |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------|
| Parting plainly or politely     | <i>Au revoir.</i>     |
| Expecting to meet again shortly | <i>À bientôt.</i>     |
| Casually saying “see you”       | <i>À plus (tard).</i> |
| Leaving for the day             | <i>À demain.</i>      |

The whole exchange, drawing on Chapters 1 through 4:

— *Salut! Je m'appelle Chloé. Comment tu t'appelles?*  
 — *Je m'appelle Marc. Enchanté.*  
 — *Ça va?*



- *Ça va bien, merci, et toi?*
- *Très bien. Bon...à demain, Marc.*
- *À demain, Chloé. Au revoir!*

What this chapter built: *au revoir*, the plain goodbye that promises a *re-seeing* (the *vidēre* family, twin of German *Auf Wiedersehen*); and *à plus tard* / *à bientôt* / *à demain* — later, soon, tomorrow, all *à* + a time, mirroring Spanish's *hasta*. You can now hold a whole short French exchange, hello to goodbye. Next chapter: your first verbs, and your first sentence built from scratch.



## Chapter 5

# The First Verbs

Until now you have assembled fixed phrases. This chapter hands you a *pattern* instead: the regular *-er* verbs, the largest verb family in French by a wide margin. Learn the one template and thousands of verbs come with it — and with it you build your first sentence that nobody handed you pre-made. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C05-\*.md.*

### 5.1 *parler* — “to speak,” the model *-er* verb

#### Sounds you’ll need

The infinitive ending *-er* is a clean “ay”: *parler* = *par-LAY* (the *r* of that ending is silent). What is left when you strip the ending is the **stem**, *parl-*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**parler** (“to speak, to talk”) ← Late Latin *parabolāre*, “to tell parables, to discourse,” from *parabola* (“a comparison, a speech”), itself from Greek *parabolē*, “a throwing-beside.” So to *speak*, in French, is at root to *tell parables*.

That root fans out into English: **parable**, the story-comparison itself; **parole**, a spoken word of honour (as a prisoner’s parole); **palaver**, a long talk; **parley**, to talk terms; and even **parliament**, a talking-place.

#### Grammar Lens

**The *-er* present tense.** Drop *-er* from the infinitive, then add the ending that belongs to the person. (*je* = I, *tu* = you familiar, *il* / *elle*

= he / she, *nous* = we, *vous* = you formal or plural, *ils* / *elles* = they.)

| Person                    | Ending | <i>parler</i>       | Sounds like    |
|---------------------------|--------|---------------------|----------------|
| <i>je</i>                 | -e     | <i>je parle</i>     | <i>parl</i>    |
| <i>tu</i>                 | -es    | <i>tu parles</i>    | <i>parl</i>    |
| <i>il</i> / <i>elle</i>   | -e     | <i>il parle</i>     | <i>parl</i>    |
| <i>nous</i>               | -ons   | <i>nous parlons</i> | <i>par-LON</i> |
| <i>vous</i>               | -ez    | <i>vous parlez</i>  | <i>par-LAY</i> |
| <i>ils</i> / <i>elles</i> | -ent   | <i>ils parlent</i>  | <i>parl</i>    |

Here is the great French surprise: **-e, -es and -ent are all silent.** *je parle*, *tu parles* and *ils parlent* sound identical — just *parl*. Only the *nous* form (-ons) and the *vous* form (-ez) are audible.

### Grammar Lens

**Why French keeps its pronouns.** That silence has a consequence which shapes the whole language. In Spanish, the ending alone tells you who is speaking — *hablo* (“I speak”) against *hablas* (“you speak”) — so the pronoun can be dropped. In French your ear cannot hear any difference between *parle*, *parles* and *parlent*, so the **pronoun must stay** to carry the person. *Je* and *tu* are not optional decoration in French; they are the only thing telling you who is doing the speaking.

## 5.2 *habiter* — “to live,” and it is about *having a place*

### Sounds you’ll need

The **h** is silent — French *h* is never pronounced. So *habiter* = *a-bee-TAY*, with the same -er = “ay” ending as *parler*.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**habiter** (“to live, to dwell”) ← Latin *habitāre*, “to dwell, to keep on having [a place]” — the **frequentative** of *habēre*, “to have.” A frequentative is a verb of repeated action, so to *dwell* somewhere is, at root, to *keep having* it as your place.

### 5.3. TRAVAILLER — “TO WORK,” AND THE TORTURE BEHIND TRAVEL 29

The root is thoroughly at home in English: **habitat**, the place a creature dwells; **inhabit**, **inhabitant**, **habitation**. And through *habēre* (“to have”) come **habit**, what you keep having, and **able** / **ability**, what you have it in you to do.

#### Grammar Lens

**The same template, silent trap and all.** Drop *-er*, add the endings — identical to *parler*:

| Person             | <i>habiter</i>       | Sounds like      |
|--------------------|----------------------|------------------|
| <i>je</i>          | <i>j’habite</i>      | <i>a-BEET</i>    |
| <i>tu</i>          | <i>tu habites</i>    | <i>a-BEET</i>    |
| <i>il / elle</i>   | <i>il habite</i>     | <i>a-BEET</i>    |
| <i>nous</i>        | <i>nous habitons</i> | <i>a-bee-TON</i> |
| <i>vous</i>        | <i>vous habitez</i>  | <i>a-bee-TAY</i> |
| <i>ils / elles</i> | <i>ils habitent</i>  | <i>a-BEET</i>    |

Note *j’habite*: *je* elides to *j’* before the vowel of *habite*. Because the *h* is silent, the word *counts* as beginning with a vowel. With this verb you can answer an *où* (“where”) question: *J’habite à Paris.* — “I live in Paris.”

### 5.3 *travailler* — “to work,” and the torture behind *travel*

#### Sounds you’ll need

The letters *-ill-* carry a *y* glide: *travailler* = *tra-va-YAY*, with the same *-er* = “ay” ending. The conjugated *je travaille* is *tra-VYE*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**travailler** (“to work”) ← Vulgar Latin *tripaliāre*, “to torture,” from *tripalium*, a Roman instrument of torture made of **three stakes** (*tri-* “three” + *pālus* “stake” → English **pale**, **impale**).

The slide of meaning is grim and perfectly logical: *torture* → *painful toil* → *work*. Two English words came down that same road: **travail**,

painful and laborious effort; and **travel**, because journeying was once such an ordeal that the word for toil became the word for taking a trip. Etymologically, you are tortured every time you travel.

### Why it's said this way

Spanish *trabajar* (“to work”) comes from the very same *tripaliāre* — a perfect cross-language twin, torture and all. The middle of the word went one way in each language: the *-al-* stayed in French (*travail*, *travailler*) and softened to *-aj-* in Spanish (*trabajo*, *trabajar*).

### Grammar Lens

**Nothing new — and that is the point.** One template, every *-er* verb:

| Person             | <i>travailler</i>       | Sounds like       |
|--------------------|-------------------------|-------------------|
| <i>je</i>          | <i>je travaille</i>     | <i>tra-VYE</i>    |
| <i>tu</i>          | <i>tu travailles</i>    | <i>tra-VYE</i>    |
| <i>il / elle</i>   | <i>il travaille</i>     | <i>tra-VYE</i>    |
| <i>nous</i>        | <i>nous travaillons</i> | <i>tra-va-YON</i> |
| <i>vous</i>        | <i>vous travaillez</i>  | <i>tra-va-YAY</i> |
| <i>ils / elles</i> | <i>ils travaillent</i>  | <i>tra-VYE</i>    |

*Je travaille à Paris.* — “I work in Paris.”

## 5.4 *Je parle français* — your first real sentence

*Je* (I, §2.1) + *parle* (speak, from *parler*, §5.1) + *français* (French) = **Je parle français**. A complete, grammatical French sentence — and the first one you assembled yourself rather than learned whole.

### Sounds you'll need

*français* = *frahñ-SEH*. The cedilla under the *ç* forces a soft *s* sound where a plain *c* would have been hard; the opening *fran-* is nasal, and the final *-ais* is a plain *eh*.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**français** (“French” — both the language and a French person) ← *Fran-cia*, “land of the **Franks**,” the Germanic people who settled Roman Gaul and gave France its name. And here is the twist: the Franks’ own name meant “**free**.” That is why English **frank** and **frankly** mean open and unguarded, and why the old French coin was called a *franc*.

### Grammar Lens

**Two rules hiding in four words.** First, you keep the *je*. Spanish drops its pronoun — *hablo español* says “I speak Spanish” with no word for “I,” because the ending *-o* carries the person. French cannot do that: *parle*, *parles* and *parlent* all sound alike (§5.1), so the pronoun must stay. This is the single biggest structural difference between French and its Iberian cousins.

Second, **no article on the language** here: *je parle français*, not *je parle le français*.

Swap the pieces and the pattern generates new sentences: *J’habite à Paris*. (“I live in Paris.”) and *Tu parles français?* (“Do you speak French?” — no extra words needed, just raise the tone at the end).

## 5.5 Making sentences with -er verbs

No new words. For the first time you are not reciting phrases — you are *building* them from a pattern. Run each verb through *je / tu / il* and listen: nothing changes.

| Verb              | <i>je</i>           | <i>tu</i>            | <i>il</i>           |
|-------------------|---------------------|----------------------|---------------------|
| <i>parler</i>     | <i>je parle</i>     | <i>tu parles</i>     | <i>il parle</i>     |
| <i>habiter</i>    | <i>j’habite</i>     | <i>tu habites</i>    | <i>il habite</i>    |
| <i>travailler</i> | <i>je travaille</i> | <i>tu travailles</i> | <i>il travaille</i> |

Every singular form — and the *ils* form too — *sounds* the same, because *-e*, *-es* and *-ent* are silent. That is exactly why *je*, *tu* and *il* stay put: they carry the person your ear cannot hear.

Now say something real:

— *Tu parles français?* — *Oui, je parle un peu.*

— Où habites-tu? — J'habite à Lyon. Et je travaille à Paris.  
 — Merci! — De rien.

(*oui* = “yes”; *un peu* = “a little”; *où* = “where”; and *merci* / *de rien* come straight back from Chapter 3.)

| French                       | English                |
|------------------------------|------------------------|
| <i>Je parle français.</i>    | I speak French.        |
| <i>Tu parles français?</i>   | Do you speak French?   |
| <i>Oui, je parle un peu.</i> | Yes, I speak a little. |
| <i>J'habite à Paris.</i>     | I live in Paris.       |
| <i>Je travaille à Lyon.</i>  | I work in Lyon.        |

What this chapter built: the **regular -er present tense** — drop *-er*, add *-e* / *-es* / *-e* / *-ons* / *-ez* / *-ent*, where the singular endings and the *ils* ending are silent, which is why the subject pronoun is mandatory. Three verbs to drill it: *parler* (from *parabolāre* — parable, parole), *habiter* (from *habitāre* — habitat, inhabit), *travailler* (from *tripalium* — travail, travel; twin of Spanish *trabajar*). And *Je parle français*, your first self-assembled sentence, with *français* from *Francia*, the land of the Franks, whose name meant “free.” French now moves in real sentences.



## Chapter 6

# Numbers One to Ten

Numbers are the most-reused words in any language, and French — like its sibling Spanish — inherited them almost unchanged from Latin. So you already half-know them from English, and a *Spanish twin* stands beside each one. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C06-\*.md.*

### 6.1 *un, deux, trois, quatre, cinq* — counting to five

#### Sounds you'll need

*un* is a nasal vowel,  $\text{œ}$  said through the nose — close to “uh” hummed nasally; no *n* is actually pronounced.

*deux* = *deuh*, with the rounded *eu*; the *x* is silent.

| French            | ← Latin         | Spanish twin  | English cousins                           |
|-------------------|-----------------|---------------|-------------------------------------------|
| <i>un</i> (1)     | <i>ūnus</i>     | <i>uno</i>    | <b>unit, union, unique, universe</b>      |
| <i>deux</i> (2)   | <i>duo</i>      | <i>dos</i>    | <b>duo, dual, duet, double</b>            |
| <i>trois</i> (3)  | <i>trēs</i>     | <i>tres</i>   | <b>trio, triple, trident, triangle</b>    |
| <i>quatre</i> (4) | <i>quattuor</i> | <i>cuatro</i> | <b>quart, quarter, quatrain, quadrant</b> |
| <i>cinq</i> (5)   | <i>quīnque</i>  | <i>cinco</i>  | <b>quintet, quintessence</b>              |

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**un** also lives on in English *a/an* and *one*; French *cinq* was borrowed straight into English as **cinque**, the 5 on dice.

Latin *ūnus, duo, trēs* barely changed on the way into French and Spanish

alike — *trois* and *tres* are the same Roman *trēs*, just worn two different ways.

### Grammar Lens

*un* → *un* / *une* (**one = a/an**). *un* doubles as the article “a/an,” and it takes gender: *un* (masculine) / *une* (feminine) — *un café* “a/one coffee,” *une bière* “a/one beer.” French makes no difference between “one” and “a,” exactly like Spanish *un/una*. The others (*deux, trois* ...) don’t change.

## 6.2 *six, sept, huit, neuf, dix* — and the calendar’s secret

The rest of the way to ten. These four hide the same fact the English and Spanish numbers do: *septembre–décembre* are just Latin for 7, 8, 9, 10. And *huit* shows how violently French can wear a Latin word down.

### Sounds you’ll need

*six* and *dix* end in an *-s* sound when counting (*sees, dees*) but go silent before a consonant (*six livres = see livres*) — a liaison quirk.

*neuf* = *nuhf*; its *f* turns to a *v* sound before a vowel (*neuf ans = neu-v-ans*).

| French          | ← Latin       | Spanish twin | English cousins                                  |
|-----------------|---------------|--------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| <i>six</i> (6)  | <i>sex</i>    | <i>seis</i>  | <b>sextet, sextant, semester</b>                 |
| <i>sept</i> (7) | <i>septem</i> | <i>siete</i> | <b>septembre</b> (the 7th month!), <b>septet</b> |
| <i>huit</i> (8) | <i>octō</i>   | <i>ocho</i>  | <b>octobre</b> (8th), <b>octave, octopus</b>     |
| <i>neuf</i> (9) | <i>novem</i>  | <i>nueve</i> | <b>novembre</b> (9th), <b>novena</b>             |
| <i>dix</i> (10) | <i>decem</i>  | <i>diez</i>  | <b>décembre</b> (10th), <b>decimal, dime</b>     |

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Look at **huit**: Latin *octō* lost its *c*, softened, and grew an *h*- prop — *octō* → *oit* → *huit*. The number is unrecognizable, but *octobre* keeps the old *oct*- intact, so the 8 is still visible in the *month*.

And *dix* gave English **dime** (a tenth of a dollar), through Old French *disme* ← *decima* “a tenth.”

### Grammar Lens

**Why the months are “off by two.”** *Septembre* means “7th,” yet it is the 9th month. Why? The old Roman year began in March, so *September* really was the seventh. Julius and Augustus later inserted *juillet* and *août* (named for themselves), shoving the counting months out of place — but the Latin numbers stuck. Every *décembre*, you are saying Roman “ten.” (Identical to the Spanish story — *diciembre* ← *decem* too.)



## Chapter 7

# The Days of the Week

The seven-day week is one of humanity’s oldest inheritances, and its day-names are a map of the sky: the Romans named each day for a planet-god. French kept that map almost intact — and then religion overwrote the last two. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C07-\*.md.*

### 7.1 *lundi* to *vendredi* — the planets of the week

Once you see the trick, five days decode at once.

#### Sounds you’ll need

*lundi* = *luh(n)-DEE*, with the nasal *un* you met in *un* (one).

The shared ending *-di* is always *DEE*.

Every French weekday ends in *-di*, which is Latin *diēs*, “day.” The first part is a planet-god. Read each one as “[god]’s day”:

| French          | ← Latin              | planet-god                      | English echo                             |
|-----------------|----------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| <i>lundi</i>    | <i>lūnae diēs</i>    | the <b>Moon</b> ( <i>lune</i> ) | <i>Monday</i> = Moon-day                 |
| <i>mardi</i>    | <i>Martis diēs</i>   | <b>Mars</b>                     | <i>Tuesday</i> (Tiw, the war-god = Mars) |
| <i>mercredi</i> | <i>Mercuriī diēs</i> | <b>Mercury</b>                  | <i>Wednesday</i> (Woden = Mercury)       |
| <i>jeudi</i>    | <i>Jovis diēs</i>    | <b>Jupiter</b> ( <i>Jove</i> )  | <i>Thursday</i> ( <b>Thor</b> = Jupiter) |
| <i>vendredi</i> | <i>Veneris diēs</i>  | <b>Venus</b>                    | <i>Friday</i> (Frigg/Freya = Venus)      |

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here’s the beautiful part: **mardi** and **Tuesday** are the same day — both “the day of the war-god” — but Latin used *Mars* while the Germanic peoples swapped in *their* war-god, *Tiw*.

The Romans mapped their gods onto the planets; the Germanic tribes then mapped *their* gods onto the Roman ones (*interpretatio germanica*). So French *jeudi* (Jupiter) and English **Thursday** (Thor) are the king-god’s day in two pantheons.

## 7.2 *samedi* and *dimanche* — the week’s religious edge

Five days named for planets — and then two that aren’t. The weekend is where religion overwrote astronomy: Saturn’s day and the Sun’s day were renamed by Judaism and Christianity, and French shows both layers.

| French          | ← Latin                               | meaning                 |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| <i>samedi</i>   | <i>sambatī diēs</i> ← <i>Sabbatum</i> | “ <b>Sabbath</b> day”   |
| <i>dimanche</i> | <i>diēs Dominica</i>                  | “the <b>Lord’s</b> day” |

*samedi* still has the *-di* (*diēs*), but the god is gone — replaced by the Hebrew *shabbat*, “rest.” In *dimanche* the *-di* jumped to the *front* (*di-manche*); *Dominica* comes from *Domīnus*, “lord, master.”

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two different rewrites.

**samedi** would have been “Saturn’s day” (as English **Saturday** still is — the one weekday English kept a Roman god for!). But Latin Christians took the Jewish **Sabbath** (*Sabbatum* ← Hebrew *shabbāt*, “to rest”) and it became *samedi*. So English *Saturday* and French *samedi* are the same day under two names — the planet versus the Sabbath.

**dimanche** dropped Sun-worship entirely: where English keeps **Sunday**, French made it *diēs Dominica*, “the Lord’s day” (*Domīnus* → English **dominion, dominate, dame**). Notice the *di-* is now in front — a fossil of *diēs* that moved.

7.2. SAMEDI AND DIMANCHE — *THE WEEK'S RELIGIOUS EDGE*39

| French          | English   |
|-----------------|-----------|
| <i>lundi</i>    | Monday    |
| <i>mardi</i>    | Tuesday   |
| <i>mercredi</i> | Wednesday |
| <i>jeudi</i>    | Thursday  |
| <i>vendredi</i> | Friday    |
| <i>samedi</i>   | Saturday  |
| <i>dimanche</i> | Sunday    |





## Chapter 8

# Telling the Time

With your numbers in hand, you can tell the time. It takes one key word, *heure* (“hour”), plus two hours that refuse a number and take a name instead: *midi* and *minuit*. Practice lessons: *lessons/FR-C08-\*.md*.

### 8.1 *heure* — the hour, and telling the time

#### Sounds you’ll need

The *h* of *heure* is silent (as in English *hour*): say *eur*.

Because it starts with a vowel-sound, the number links onto it: *deux heures* = *deu-z-eur*, *trois heures* = *troi-z-eur*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**heure** ← Latin *hōra* ← Greek *hōrā*. The Greek word meant “a period, a season, the right time” (the goddesses of the seasons were the *Horae*); Latin narrowed it to “hour,” and French wore *hōra* down to *heure*.

English took the same Latin *hōra* and made **hour** — so *heure* and *hour* are the same word, spelt apart. (The silent *h* in both is a fossil of the Latin spelling.)

#### Grammar Lens

***il est ... heure(s)***. To tell the clock time, French says *il est* (“it is”) + the number + *heure(s)*. Literally “it is two *hours*” — French counts the hours, where English says “o’clock” (itself a worn-down “of the clock”). Add *et quart* (“and a quarter”), *et demie* (“and a half”), *moins le quart* (“quarter to”) later; the core is *il est ... heures*.

| French                     | English            | note                        |
|----------------------------|--------------------|-----------------------------|
| <i>Il est une heure.</i>   | It is one o'clock. | <i>une heure</i> — singular |
| <i>Il est deux heures.</i> | It is two o'clock. | <i>deux heures</i> — plural |
| <i>Il est dix heures.</i>  | It is ten o'clock. |                             |

## 8.2 *midi* and *minuit* — noon and midnight

Two hours don't get a number — they get a name. *midi* (noon) and *minuit* (midnight) are the pivots of the day, and both are literally “the middle” of the day and of the night.

| French        | ← Latin            | literally               |
|---------------|--------------------|-------------------------|
| <i>midi</i>   | <i>medius diēs</i> | “the <b>mid-day</b> ”   |
| <i>minuit</i> | <i>media nox</i>   | “the <b>mid-night</b> ” |

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**midi** = *medius diēs*, “mid-day.” You can still see both halves: *mi-* is “middle” (from *medius*, cousin of English **medium**, **mid**, **middle**), and *-di* is the *diēs* “day” you met in *lundi* and *mardi*. So *midi* is “the day's middle.”

**minuit** = *media nox*, “mid-night.” Here *mi-* is again “middle,” and *-nuit* is *nox/noct-*, “night” (cousin of English **night**, and the *noct-* of **nocturnal**). So *minuit* is “the night's middle” — exactly like English **mid-night**.

To use them, drop the *heures* — they *are* the hour: *Il est midi*. “It is noon.” *Il est minuit*. “It is midnight.”

### Why it's said this way

English **noon** comes from Latin *nōna hōra*, “the *ninth* hour” — once mid-afternoon, it drifted earlier until it landed on midday. French kept the tidier “mid-day.”

## Chapter 9

# Months and Seasons

The French calendar is a procession of Roman gods and emperors, carried almost unchanged out of Latin — and the four seasons are four small Latin poems about heat, sleep, and first things. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C09-\*.md.*

### 9.1 *les mois* — the calendar’s gods and Caesars

The twelve French months are a **procession of Roman gods and emperors**, almost unchanged from Latin. Two of them pay off twice: *mars* is the war-god who also names Tuesday, and *septembre–décembre* are still the Latin numbers seven to ten.

| French           | ← Latin           | who / what                                                |
|------------------|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>janvier</i>   | <i>Januarius</i>  | <b>Janus</b> , two-faced god of doors and beginnings      |
| <i>février</i>   | <i>Februarius</i> | <i>Februa</i> , the Roman <b>purification</b> festival    |
| <i>mars</i>      | <i>Martius</i>    | <b>Mars</b> , the war-god                                 |
| <i>avril</i>     | <i>Aprilis</i>    | perhaps <i>aperire</i> , “to <b>open</b> ” (buds opening) |
| <i>mai</i>       | <i>Maius</i>      | <b>Maia</b> , goddess of growth                           |
| <i>juin</i>      | <i>Junius</i>     | <b>Juno</b> , queen of the gods                           |
| <i>juillet</i>   | <i>Julius</i>     | <b>Julius Caesar</b> (he inserted this month)             |
| <i>août</i>      | <i>Augustus</i>   | the emperor <b>Augustus</b> (he inserted this one)        |
| <i>septembre</i> | <i>september</i>  | “ <b>7th</b> ” ( <i>septem</i> )                          |
| <i>octobre</i>   | <i>october</i>    | “ <b>8th</b> ” ( <i>octo</i> )                            |
| <i>novembre</i>  | <i>november</i>   | “ <b>9th</b> ” ( <i>novem</i> )                           |
| <i>décembre</i>  | <i>december</i>   | “ <b>10th</b> ” ( <i>decem</i> )                          |

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**mars = Mars = mardi.** The month and the weekday honour the *same* war-god — *Martius* (his month) and *Martis diēs* (his day). Spot one, and you know the other.

**The 7–10 months.** *Septembre* through *décembre* still carry *septem*, *octo*, *novem*, *decem* — because the old Roman year began in **March**, so September really *was* the seventh month. Then **Julius** and **Augustus** shoved two months in (*juillet*, *août*), the counting slid out of place — but the names stuck.

### Why it's said this way

Two of the twelve are named for *people* rather than gods: *juillet* for Julius Caesar and *août* for the emperor Augustus. Each man put his own month into the calendar, and two thousand years later France still says their names every summer.

## 9.2 *les saisons* — the four seasons

Four words for the turning year: **le printemps**, **l'été**, **l'automne**, **l'hiver**. Each traces to Latin, and the first one is a small poem — *printemps* means, almost literally, “the first time.”

| French                       | ← Latin                  | literally                                      |
|------------------------------|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <i>le printemps</i> (spring) | <i>prīnum tempus</i>     | “the <b>first time</b> / <b>prime season</b> ” |
| <i>l'été</i> (summer)        | <i>aestās / aestātem</i> | “heat, the hot season”                         |
| <i>l'automne</i> (autumn)    | <i>autumnus</i>          | “autumn” — the word English borrowed           |
| <i>l'hiver</i> (winter)      | <i>hibernum (tempus)</i> | “the <b>wintry</b> season”                     |

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**printemps** = *prime* + *temps* (“time, weather”): the year’s *first* season, its “prime time.” Older French used *primevère* — the same *prima vera* (“first spring”) that Italian keeps as *primavera*.

**été** ← *aestās*, “heat” — summer as the hot season; English **estival** (also spelled **aestival**) means “of summer.”

**automne** ← *autumnus*: the *m* stayed in the spelling, the *n* went silent.

**hiver** ← *hibernum*, “wintry” — and English **hibernate** is literally “to spend the winter.” Same root: one a season, one a bear’s sleep.

### Grammar Lens

**Saying “in” a season.** Spring is the odd one out: *au printemps*, but *en été* / *en automne* / *en hiver*. Only spring takes *au*.



## Chapter 10

# Family

Four words — father, mother, brother, sister — and every one of them is among the oldest words we can reconstruct, older than Latin, older than Rome. Each is also a key to a whole shelf of English vocabulary. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C10-\*.md.*

### 10.1 *le père, la mère* — the oldest words in the family

The words for “father” and “mother” are among the **oldest words we can reconstruct**. French kept them almost bare: **père** and **mère**. And they are secretly the *same words* as English **father** and **mother**.

| French         | English    |
|----------------|------------|
| <i>le père</i> | the father |
| <i>la mère</i> | the mother |

Note the articles: *le* père is masculine, *la* mère is feminine — the gender you have been tracking since the first chapter.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**le père** (“father”) ← Latin *pater* ← Proto-Indo-European *\*ph<sub>2</sub>tér*.

**la mère** (“mother”) ← Latin *māter* ← Proto-Indo-European *\*méh<sub>2</sub>tēr*.

The Latin root also gives English its “of a parent” adjectives: **paternal**, **paternity**, **patron**; and **maternal**, **maternity**, **matron**, and even **matter** (*māter* → *materia*, “the stuff a tree-mother makes”).

## Grammar Lens

**One sound-law, two languages.** French took *pater* and *māter* straight from Latin. English took the *same* Proto-Indo-European words down a different road, through **Grimm’s law**, which turned  $p \rightarrow f$  and  $t \rightarrow th$ :

| Proto-Indo-European        | Latin / French             | English       |
|----------------------------|----------------------------|---------------|
| <i>*ph<sub>2</sub>tér</i>  | <i>pater</i> → <i>père</i> | <b>father</b> |
| <i>*méh<sub>2</sub>tēr</i> | <i>māter</i> → <i>mère</i> | <b>mother</b> |

So *père* and *father* are not lookalikes borrowed late — they are the **same inherited word**, one keeping the *p*, the other shifting it to *f*.

10.2 *le frère, la sœur* — brother and sister

With parents in hand, the next pair: **frère** (“brother”) and **sœur** (“sister”). Both come straight from Latin, and both hand English a whole family of words.

| French          | English     |
|-----------------|-------------|
| <i>le frère</i> | the brother |
| <i>la sœur</i>  | the sister  |

## Sounds you’ll need

**sœur** is spelled with *œ* — an *o* and an *e* fused into a single letter. It spells the vowel that *soror* wore down to: *soror* → *seror* → *sœur*. Spell it aloud as “s-œ-u-r,” remembering that the *œ* counts as *one* letter.

## The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**le frère** (“brother”) ← Latin *frāter* ← Proto-Indo-European *\*b<sup>h</sup>réh<sub>2</sub>tēr* — the same root that, through Grimm’s law ( $b^h \rightarrow b$ ), gave English **brother**. It also gives **fraternal**, **fraternity**, **fraternize**, and — softened in old French — **friar**, a “brother” in a religious order.

**la sœur** (“sister”) ← Latin *soror*, behind English **sorority** and **sororal**; and a sister in a convent is still called a *sœur*. English **sister** comes from the *same* Proto-Indo-European root *\*swésōr*, by the Germanic road —



Latin *soror* and English *sister* are cousins.

The four family words now form a set — *père, mère, frère, sœur* — and each one is a key to a Latin-through-English word: **p**aternal, **m**aternal, **f**raternal, **s**orority.



## Chapter 11

# Bread, Water, Wine

Food at last — and three words that sit at the centre of the French table. One of them hides the loveliest word-story in English; another is the most worn-down word French ever took from Latin. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C11-\*.md.*

### 11.1 *le pain* — bread, and the people you share it with

**le pain** (“bread”) is the heart of the French table — and its Latin root hides one of the loveliest word-stories in English: your **companion** is, literally, someone you **share bread** with.

#### Sounds you’ll need

*le pain* carries the nasal vowel spelled *-ain*: the air goes through the nose, and the final *-n* is not pronounced as a separate consonant. It is masculine: *le pain*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**le pain** (“bread”) ← Latin *pānis*. The root *pān-* feeds a surprising table of English words:

**companion** / **company** ← *com-* (“with”) + *pānis* — “one you break bread with.” A *company* was first a group sharing meals.

**pantry** — the room where the bread (and the rest of the food) is kept.

**pannier** — a bread-basket, now the bag slung over a bicycle or a donkey.

**Why it's said this way**

So *le pain* is the same root as **companion**: French kept the bread, English kept the friendship built on it. Two useful everyday forms: *un pain* (“a loaf”) and *du pain* (“some bread”).

**11.2 *l'eau, le vin* — water and wine**

The two drinks of the French table. One of them, **eau**, is the single most **worn-down** word French took from Latin: it began as *aqua* and ended as a bare “oh.”

| French        | English   |
|---------------|-----------|
| <i>l'eau</i>  | the water |
| <i>le vin</i> | the wine  |

**Sounds you'll need**

*l'eau* is pronounced simply “oh” — three letters, *e-a-u*, spelling one vowel sound. It takes *l'* rather than *le* or *la* because it begins with a vowel. *le vin* has the nasal vowel of *-in*.

**The word, taken apart — and its English cousins**

**l'eau** (“water”) ← Latin *aqua*. Watch the erosion: *aqua* → *ewe* → *eaue* → *eau*, until only the vowel “oh” remains. French quite literally *drank the consonants out of aqua*.

The original *aqua* is still loud in English, because English borrowed the Latin word *whole*: **aquatic**, **aquarium**, **aqueduct**, **aqualung** — and Italian *acqua* barely changed at all. So *l'eau* and *aquarium* are the far ends of the same word.

**le vin** (“wine”) ← Latin *vīnum*. Unlike *eau*, this one held its shape, and English shares it: **wine** itself is *vīnum* borrowed into old Germanic, plus **vine**, **vinegar** (*vin* + *aigre*, “sour wine”), **vintage**, **vineyard**, **vinyl**. Wine mattered enough to keep its name across every border.

## Chapter 12

# Numbers Eleven to Twenty

The French teens are not built the way you would guess. Six of them came out of Latin already welded together; then, at exactly seventeen, the language changes its mind in front of you. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C12-\*.md.*

### 12.1 *onze* → *seize* — six numbers welded together

French did not say “ten-one, ten-two.” It inherited six numbers already **fused** in Latin, and they came through almost unrecognisable.

|    | French          | ← Latin              | literally   |
|----|-----------------|----------------------|-------------|
| 11 | <i>onze</i>     | <i>ūndecim</i>       | “one-ten”   |
| 12 | <i>douze</i>    | <i>duodecim</i>      | “two-ten”   |
| 13 | <i>treize</i>   | <i>trēdecim</i>      | “three-ten” |
| 14 | <i>quatorze</i> | <i>quattuordecim</i> | “four-ten”  |
| 15 | <i>quinze</i>   | <i>quīndecim</i>     | “five-ten”  |
| 16 | <i>seize</i>    | <i>sēdecim</i>       | “six-ten”   |

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Look at the ending they all share: **-ze**. That is Latin *decem* (“ten”), worn down to almost nothing — the *same* ten that hides in *dix* (10) and in *décembre*, the old tenth month. One root, three disguises.

#### Grammar Lens

**The digit is still in there.** The front of each word is the small number it is built on: *un* → *on-*, *deux* → *dou-*, *trois* → *trei-*, *quatre* → *quator-*, *cinq* → *quin-*, *six* → *sei-*. Say them slowly and the small number

surfaces. Note the order: the *digit* comes first and the *ten* second — *trēdecim* is “three-ten,” not “ten-three.”

## 12.2 *dix-sept* → *vingt* — where French changes its mind

Here is something you can *watch happen*. Up to *seize* (16), French used the old welded-together Latin numbers. Then, at **17**, it simply gives up — and starts saying the numbers plainly, the way a child would.

|    | French          | how it is built                    |
|----|-----------------|------------------------------------|
| 16 | <i>seize</i>    | one fused word (← <i>sēdecim</i> ) |
| 17 | <i>dix-sept</i> | “ten-seven” — two words, plainly   |
| 18 | <i>dix-huit</i> | “ten-eight”                        |
| 19 | <i>dix-neuf</i> | “ten-nine”                         |
| 20 | <i>vingt</i>    | ← <i>vīgintī</i>                   |

### Grammar Lens

**Two things change at the seam.** In *seize*, the digit came *first* (“six-ten”). In *dix-sept*, the *ten* comes first (“ten-seven”). So at exactly 17 French switched both its **strategy** (fused → transparent) and its **direction** (digit-first → ten-first) — a visible seam in the counting system. Latin itself wobbled here: it had *septendecim* for 17, but for 18 and 19 it counted *down* from twenty — *duodēvīgintī*, “two-from-twenty.” The daughter languages all abandoned that subtraction trick.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**vingt** (20) ← Latin *vīgintī*, the root behind English **vigesimal** (“counting by twenties”) — and the reason French later builds *quatre-vingts* (80 = “four twenties”).

## Chapter 13

# Colours

Four basic colours — *noir*, *blanc*, *rouge*, *bleu* — and a surprise inside them: half of them are not Latin at all. Two walked down from Rome; two walked in from the Germanic north, against the usual direction of traffic. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C13-\*.md.*

### 13.1 *noir*, *blanc* — one inherited, one borrowed

Two colours, two completely different life stories. One walked straight down from Latin. The other was borrowed from the Germanic neighbours — and that direction, Germanic *into* Romance, is the opposite of what usually happens.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**noir** (“black”) ← Latin *niger*. No surprises: *niger* → *negro* / *nero* in the sister languages, and into English in **denigrate** (“to blacken someone’s name”).

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**blanc** (“white”) is the imported one. You’d expect Latin *albus* (“white”). It’s not there. French says *blanc*, from Frankish *\*blank* — a Germanic word meaning “**shining, gleaming**.” The Franks who gave France its name gave it its word for white too.

Why did *albus* lose? Probably because *blank* was *vivid*: not just “white” but “bright, flashing.” Colour words often get replaced by the more dramatic option.

*Albus* didn’t die — it stopped being a colour:

| Word                 | Meaning  | The white inside            |
|----------------------|----------|-----------------------------|
| <i>aube</i>          | dawn     | the sky going <i>white</i>  |
| <i>aubépine</i>      | hawthorn | the “white thorn”           |
| <b>album</b> (Eng.)  | album    | a <i>blank white</i> tablet |
| <b>albino</b> (Eng.) | albino   | white-skinned               |

So Latin’s white is still all around you — just never where you’d look for it.

### Grammar Lens

**Say them.** *noir, blanc*. Then put them to work on a noun you already have: *le vin blanc, le vin rouge*. And hold the pairing in your head — *noir* from Latin, *blanc* from the Franks. Say *l’aube* and hear the old Latin white still sitting inside it.

## 13.2 *rouge, bleu* — an ancient word and a borrowed one

The last section gave one inherited colour and one borrowed. This one repeats the pattern — and shows that French’s borrowing from Germanic wasn’t a one-off.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**rouge** (“red”) ← Latin *rubeus* (“reddish”). But *rubeus* itself descends from a root so old it predates Latin: Proto-Indo-European *\*h<sub>1</sub>rewdʰ-*. Its children are everywhere.

| Language | Word                                              |
|----------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Latin    | <i>ruber, rubeus</i> → <i>rouge, ruby, rubric</i> |
| English  | <b>red, rust, ruddy</b>                           |
| German   | <i>rot</i>                                        |

So *rouge* and **red** are not lookalikes — they are *actual cousins*, separated for maybe five thousand years. Red is one of humanity’s oldest named colours.



### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**bleu** (“blue”) ← Frankish *\*blāo*. Another Germanic word, borrowed exactly like *blanc*. And then something neat happened: English took *bleu* from French — so English **blue** is a Germanic word that went to France, changed clothes, and came back. German kept the original at home: *blau*.

### Why it’s said this way

French also has *azur* (from the same source as Spanish *azul*, ultimately Arabic *lāzaward*, “lapis lazuli”) — the poetic blue of the sky, and the *Côte d’Azur*.

The pattern of the chapter, laid out:

| Colour       | Source                                 |
|--------------|----------------------------------------|
| <i>noir</i>  | Latin <i>niger</i>                     |
| <i>blanc</i> | Germanic <i>*blank</i>                 |
| <i>rouge</i> | Latin <i>rubeus</i> (ancient PIE root) |
| <i>bleu</i>  | Germanic <i>*blāo</i>                  |

Half of French’s basic colour vocabulary walked in from the north.

### Why it’s said this way

Say them in the order of the flag: *bleu*, *blanc*, *rouge*. All three are now yours — and two of the three are loanwords. The French tricolour is, quietly, two-thirds Germanic.

### Grammar Lens

**Practice.** Say *rouge*, *bleu*. Say *le vin rouge* — the wine you already know, now with its colour. Say the cousins out loud in a row: *rouge* · **red** · *rot*. Next chapter: the verb *avoir*, and something French does with it that English would never do.



## Chapter 14

# To Have, and How Old You Are

The verb French leans on hardest, and the first thing it lets you say that English cannot say the same way: your age. French does not *be* twenty — it *has* twenty years. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C14-\*.md.*

### 14.1 *avoir* — “to have”

The verb French leans on hardest. It’s irregular, it’s everywhere, and — as you’ll see — you have already met its root without knowing it.

| Singular                      | Plural                           |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| <i>j’ai</i> (I have)          | <i>nous avons</i> (we have)      |
| <i>tu as</i> (you have)       | <i>vous avez</i> (you have)      |
| <i>il/elle a</i> (he/she has) | <i>ils/elles ont</i> (they have) |

#### Sounds you’ll need

Say the singular column: *ai*, *as*, *a* — three forms, and they all sound the *same*. The written endings differ; your ear can’t tell them apart. Only the pronoun tells you who.

Note *j’ai*, not *je ai*: before a vowel, *je* loses its *e*. That is the elision French does everywhere — the same move that turns *le eau* into *l’eau*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**avoir** (“to have”) ← Latin *habēre*. And the verb *habiter* (“to live somewhere”) ← *habitāre* — which is just *habēre* run through a “keep doing it” pattern: *to keep having a place*. Same root, both verbs.

The family in English is large, because English borrowed it whole:

| English word    | Inside it                                 |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------|
| <b>habit</b>    | what you <i>have</i> regularly            |
| <b>inhabit</b>  | to <i>have</i> a place — = <i>habiter</i> |
| <b>exhibit</b>  | to <i>hold</i> out                        |
| <b>prohibit</b> | to <i>hold</i> back                       |

### Grammar Lens

**How far it wore down.** Latin *habeō* (“I have”) → French *j’ai*. Four syllables of Latin reduced to a *single vowel sound*. French does this more than any of its sisters — compare Italian *ho*, Spanish *he*, and the Latin *aqua* that French ground down to *eau*.

### Sounds you’ll need

**Practice.** Say the six: *j’ai, tu as, il a, nous avons, vous avez, ils ont*. Then say the three that sound alike — *ai · as · a*. Then a whole sentence: *J’ai un frère* (“I have a brother”). Then the root pair: *avoir · habiter*.

## 14.2 *j’ai vingt ans* — having your years

Ask a French speaker their age and the answer uses *avoir*. Not “I am twenty” — “**I have twenty years.**” English can’t do this; Spanish and Italian do exactly the same thing.

— *Quel âge as-tu ?* — “What age do you have?”  
 — *J’ai vingt ans.* — “I have twenty years.”

### Grammar Lens

Two things to notice. First, the verb is **avoir**, never *être* — *je suis vingt ans* is simply wrong. Second, *ans* is compulsory: English drops it (“I’m twenty”); French cannot.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**an** (“year”) ← Latin *annus*, which gives English **annual**, **anniversary**, **annals**, and *per annum*. You have already met its descendants: the month names come from the same calendar.

**Sounds you'll need**

Careful with the sound: *an* is **nasal**, and in *vingt ans* the silent *t* of *vingt* wakes up and links — *vin-t-an*. That is **liaison**, French's habit of reviving a dead consonant when a vowel follows.

Who else does it this way:

| Language   | "I am 20"                               | Verb |
|------------|-----------------------------------------|------|
| French     | <i>j'<b>ai</b> vingt <b>ans</b></i>     | have |
| Spanish    | <i><b>tengo</b> veinte años</i>         | have |
| Italian    | <i><b>ho</b> venti anni</i>             | have |
| Portuguese | <i><b>tenho</b> vinte anos</i>          | have |
| German     | <i>ich <b>bin</b> zwanzig Jahre alt</i> | be   |
| English    | <i>I <b>am</b> twenty</i>               | be   |

A clean split: **Romance has its years; Germanic is its years.** Age as something you *carry* versus age as something you *are*.

**Why it's said this way**

**Practice.** Say *Quel âge as-tu ?* Then *J'ai vingt ans*, with the liaison — *vin-t-an*. Then your own age, using the numbers you have. Then the split itself: French *a* its years; English *is* its years. Next chapter: what French builds *out of avoir* — a whole past tense.



## Chapter 15

# The Compound Past

French’s everyday past tense is built out of *avoir* — and it began life not as a tense at all, but as a sentence about *possessing* something. Then we meet the older past it pushed out of the language. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C15-\*.md.*

### 15.1 *j’ai parlé* — the past built from “have”

French’s everyday past tense. You already have both halves of it: the verb *avoir*, and the *-er* verbs.

*avoir (conjugated) + past participle*

| Infinitive     | Ends in    | Participle    |
|----------------|------------|---------------|
| <i>parler</i>  | <i>-er</i> | <i>parlé</i>  |
| <i>habiter</i> | <i>-er</i> | <i>habité</i> |
| <i>finir</i>   | <i>-ir</i> | <i>fini</i>   |
| <i>vendre</i>  | <i>-re</i> | <i>vendu</i>  |

So:

| French                  | English                 |
|-------------------------|-------------------------|
| <i>j’ai parlé</i>       | I spoke / I have spoken |
| <i>tu as parlé</i>      | you spoke               |
| <i>il a parlé</i>       | he spoke                |
| <i>nous avons parlé</i> | we spoke                |
| <i>ils ont parlé</i>    | they spoke              |

Only *avoir* changes. The participle sits there unchanged.

**Sounds you'll need**

*parler*, *parlé* and *parlez* are all pronounced *the same*. Three spellings, one sound — the context tells you which.

**The word, taken apart — and its English cousins**

Where the endings come from: *parlé* ← Latin *-ātum*; *fini* ← *-ītum*; *vendu* ← *-ūtum*. The same *-t-* that English kept in **finite**, **acute**, **statute**.

A footnote on the third one: *-ūtus* was a *rare* ending in Latin (*minūtus*, *tribūtus*). French and Italian took that small class and spread it over a whole conjugation. So *-é* and *-i* are straight inheritance; *-u* is mostly the language tidying up by analogy.

**Grammar Lens**

**The buried possessive.** Here is why this tense exists. Latin could say *habēo litterās scriptās* — “I *have* letters *written*.”

That is not a past tense. It is *avoir* in its ordinary sense — I *possess* some letters — with *scriptās* as an **adjective** describing them, agreeing with *litterās* in gender and number.

Over centuries the phrase stopped meaning “I possess a written thing” and started meaning simply “**I wrote**.” A possessive construction hardened into a tense.

And the fossil is still visible: when the object comes *first*, the participle still agrees with it, exactly as an adjective would — *Les lettres que j'ai écrites*, “The letters that I wrote.” That *-es* is a two-thousand-year-old adjective ending doing its old job.

**Sounds you'll need**

**Practice.** Say the set: *j'ai parlé*, *tu as parlé*, *il a parlé*, *nous avons parlé*, *ils ont parlé*. Say the three homophones — *parler* · *parlé* · *parlez*. Say *J'ai travaillé* (“I worked”). Then say the old meaning out loud: “I *have* a thing *spoken*.”



## 15.2 *il parla* — the past you read but never say

French has a *second* past tense. You will meet it in every novel and never hear it spoken. Knowing why is worth more than knowing its endings.

|            | <i>Passé simple</i>  | <i>Passé composé</i> |
|------------|----------------------|----------------------|
| he spoke   | <i>il parla</i>      | <i>il a parlé</i>    |
| they spoke | <i>ils parlèrent</i> | <i>ils ont parlé</i> |
| he had     | <i>il eut</i>        | <i>il a eu</i>       |

You do *not* need to produce these. You need to recognise them, because they fill the past tense of essentially all French literature.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**il parla** ← Vulgar Latin *\*parabolāvit* — the plain Latin perfect, handed straight down. Which means the *passé simple* is the *same tense* as Spanish *habló* and Portuguese *falou*.

| Language   | “he spoke”      | Status               |
|------------|-----------------|----------------------|
| French     | <i>il parla</i> | books only           |
| Spanish    | <i>habló</i>    | everyday speech      |
| Portuguese | <i>falou</i>    | everyday speech      |
| Italian    | <i>parlò</i>    | regional — see below |

Same Latin ancestor, four different fates.

### Grammar Lens

**The retreat, three times over.** French is not alone.

| Language | Simple past           | What replaced it in speech                    |
|----------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| French   | <i>passé simple</i>   | <i>passé composé</i> ( <i>j’ai parlé</i> )    |
| German   | <i>Präteritum</i>     | <i>Perfekt</i> ( <i>ich habe gesagt</i> )     |
| Italian  | <i>passato remoto</i> | <i>passato prossimo</i> ( <i>ho parlato</i> ) |

Three languages — two Romance, one Germanic — each built a compound past out of “have,” and each let that compound push the inherited simple past out of everyday conversation and into writing.

**Why it's said this way**

Not three separate inventions, though. They are **neighbours**: France, southern Germany and northern Italy form a connected block, and the change spread through it by *contact* over the same few centuries. Linguists call this an *areal* change — one that travels across language boundaries because the speakers do.

And Spanish and Portuguese, out at the western edge of that block, largely *didn't* get it. They kept their simple past where it was. (Though Spain's Spanish has since started drifting the same way, with *he hablado* taking ground from *habló* — the change reaching the edge late.)

**Sounds you'll need**

**Practice.** Say the pair — *il parla ... il a parlé*. Say the sisters — *il parla · habló · falou · parlò*. Remind yourself where you'd meet it: in a *novel*, not a conversation. And say the three retreats — *passé simple · Präteritum · passato remoto*. Next chapter: the other auxiliary, and the verbs that refuse *avoir*.

## Chapter 16

# To Be, and the Past That Takes It

The partner of *avoir*, and the most irregular verb in the language — for a reason worth knowing. Then the small group of verbs that refuse *avoir* in the past and take *être* instead. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C16-\*.md.*

### 16.1 *être* — “to be”

The other verb everything is built on. *Avoir* was one half; this is its partner — and it is the most irregular verb in French.

| Singular                       | Plural                           |
|--------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| <i>je suis</i> (I am)          | <i>nous sommes</i> (we are)      |
| <i>tu es</i> (you are)         | <i>vous êtes</i> (you are)       |
| <i>il/elle est</i> (he/she is) | <i>ils/elles sont</i> (they are) |

There is no pattern to find. Don’t look for one — these are among the oldest word-shapes in Europe, worn smooth by three thousand years of daily use.

#### Grammar Lens

**Three stems in a trench coat.** Line the forms up against Latin and the seams show.

| French             | ← Latin                                                     |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>je suis</i>     | <i>sum</i> — “I am”                                         |
| <i>tu es</i>       | <i>es</i>                                                   |
| <i>il est</i>      | <i>est</i>                                                  |
| <i>nous sommes</i> | <i>sumus</i>                                                |
| <i>ils sont</i>    | <i>sunt</i>                                                 |
| <i>être</i>        | * <i>essere</i> , Vulgar Latin’s remodelling of <i>esse</i> |

All of those come from *esse*, “to be” — the infinitive included. Now the pieces that come from somewhere else entirely:

| French                                                | ← Latin                               |
|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <i>je fus</i> , <i>il fut</i> ( <i>passé simple</i> ) | <i>fuī</i> — an ancient perfect stem  |
| <i>été</i> (past participle)                          | <i>stāre</i> — “to stand”             |
| <i>étant</i> (present participle)                     | <i>stāre</i> again ( <i>stantem</i> ) |
| <i>j’étais</i> , <i>il était</i> (imperfect)          | <i>stāre</i> again ( <i>stābam</i> )  |

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

*Fus* and *été* are not related to *suis* at all. The first is an ancient perfect stem (from Proto-Indo-European \**b<sup>h</sup>uH-*, “grow, become” — the source of English **be**); the second is the Latin verb for **standing**.

And look how much of *stāre* is in there. It isn’t one stray form: *every* French *être* form beginning *ét-* comes from the standing verb — *été*, *étant*, *étais*, *était*. A whole limb of the verb.

#### Grammar Lens

Three stems, then: *es-* for the present and infinitive, *fu-* for the *passé simple*, *ét-* for the participles and the imperfect. That patching is called **suppletion** — one verb’s paradigm filled in with pieces of another, exactly like English *go* / *went* (where *went* was stolen from *wend*).

#### Why it’s said this way

**The Spanish connection.** *Stāre* should look familiar. It is the verb Spanish turned into *estar*, its second “to be,” held apart from *ser*. So Spanish has *ser* ← *esse* and *estar* ← *stāre*, kept as two separate verbs; French has one verb, *être* ← *esse*, having absorbed *stāre*’s whole *ét-* limb. Spanish kept the two verbs *apart* and made you choose between them.

French kept one verb and swallowed a large piece of the other. Same two Latin sources, opposite solutions.

(*Stāre* also left French words outside *être* — *rester* ← *re-stāre*, “to stay,” and *coûter* ← *constāre*. What it did *not* do is survive as a separate “to be” the way *estar* did.)

### Sounds you’ll need

**Practice.** Say the six: *je suis, tu es, il est, nous sommes, vous êtes, ils sont*. Say two whole sentences: *Je suis français, Je suis fatigué*. Then say the seam — *suis* ← *sum* ... *fus* ← *fuī* ... *ét-* ← *stāre*. And the English parallel: *go / went*.

## 16.2 *je suis allé* — the past built from “be”

The last chapter built the past with *avoir*: *j’ai parlé*. But a small, important group of verbs refuses *avoir* and takes *être* instead — and when they do, something visible happens to the participle.

*Verbs of motion and change of state take être.*

*Aller* (“to go”) is the headline case:

| French                          | English   |
|---------------------------------|-----------|
| <i>je <b>suis</b> allé</i>      | I went    |
| <i>tu <b>es</b> allé</i>        | you went  |
| <i>il <b>est</b> allé</i>       | he went   |
| <i>nous <b>sommes</b> allés</i> | we went   |
| <i>ils <b>sont</b> allés</i>    | they went |

Others in the family: *venir* (come), *partir* (leave), *arriver* (arrive), *entrer*, *sortir*, *monter*, *descendre*, *naître* (be born), *mourir* (die), *rester* (stay), *tomber* (fall). Read that list as a shape rather than a list: **going, coming, being born, dying** — arriving and leaving, in space or in life.

Plus one whole extra family: all pronominal verbs take *être* — *je me suis levé, elle s’est lavée*. Careful, though: they take *être* but they do *not* follow *être*’s agreement rule. See the warning at the end of this section.

**Grammar Lens**

Two warnings, so the rule doesn't mislead you.

**Not every motion verb qualifies.** *Marcher, courir, nager, danser, voyager* all take *avoir* (*j'ai couru*). The *être* verbs are about arriving, leaving, and changing state — not about moving your legs.

**Some switch when they take an object.** *Monter, descendre, sortir, rentrer, passer* take *être* alone (*je suis monté*, “I went up”) but *avoir* with a direct object (*j'ai monté les valises*, “I took the suitcases up”).

**The participle agrees with the subject.** This is the part you can see and hear:

| French                    | English         |
|---------------------------|-----------------|
| <i>Il est allé.</i>       | He went.        |
| <i>Elle est allée.</i>    | She went.       |
| <i>Ils sont allés.</i>    | They went.      |
| <i>Elles sont allées.</i> | They (f.) went. |

The participle takes the subject's gender and number — exactly like an adjective.

**Grammar Lens**

**Why?** The same fossil as the last chapter. *Elle est allée* began as a plain description: “*she is gone*” — *gone* describing *her*, the way *elle est fatiguée* describes her. It was never an action she performed on something; it was a state she was in. So the participle agreed with her, and it still does.

Compare the two halves of the system:

| Auxiliary    | Participle agrees with                                            | Because it was...        |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| <i>avoir</i> | a <b>preceding object</b> ( <i>les lettres que j'ai écrites</i> ) | “I have letters written” |
| <i>être</i>  | the <b>subject</b> ( <i>elle est allée</i> )                      | “she is gone”            |

One rule underneath both: **the participle was an adjective, and it agrees with whatever it described.**

## Grammar Lens

**The pronominal exception.** Pronominal verbs take *être* — but their agreement follows the *avoir* rule, not the *être* one. They agree with a preceding direct object, which usually *is* the reflexive pronoun, and sometimes isn’t.

*Elle s’est lavée.* — She washed *herself*; *se* is the direct object, so it agrees.

*Elle s’est lavé les mains.* — She washed *her hands*; the object is *les mains*, and it follows, so no agreement.

*Elles se sont parlé.* — They spoke *to each other*; *se* is indirect, so no agreement.

Which is, satisfyingly, the same rule as the last chapter all along. The auxiliary looks like *être*; the agreement behaves like *avoir*. Don’t let the first mislead you about the second.

One group in particular escapes even that. Verbs that exist *only* in pronominal form — *se souvenir* (remember), *s’enfuir* (flee), *s’évanouir* (faint) — have no non-reflexive version for the pronoun to be an object *of*, so they simply agree with the subject: *elles se sont souvenues*.

## Sounds you’ll need

**Practice.** Say *je suis allé, il est allé, elle est allée*. Say the contrast — *j’ai parlé ... je suis allé*. Say the shape of the list: going, coming, born, dying. And say the reason out loud: “*she is gone*” — *gone* describes *her*.

You now have two verbs holding up the whole language, *avoir* and *être*; a past tense built from each; and the single old idea — the participle as an adjective — that explains both. That is a working past. The next volume turns from what has happened to what is in front of you: describing what you see.